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IMPACT OF WORK LIFE BALANCE PRACTICES ON EMPLOYEE RETENTION IN INDIAN ORGANISATION'S

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ABSTRACT:

The relationship between work-life balance practices and employee retention in organisations is what this study is about. It looks at how work-life balance support affects employees decisions to stay with their employer. This includes things like working arrangements, supervisor support and work overload. The reason for this study is that Indian organisations are having a time keeping good employees. They have to deal with lot of demands on employees time and energy from their family and society. Indian organisations need to keep employees and study helps them understand how to do that. Work-life balance practices very important for employee retention, in organisations.

Keywords: *Work-Life Balance, Employee Retention, Work-Life Balance Practices, Supervisor Support, Flexible Working Arrangements, Work Overload, Employee Well-being, Indian Organisations*

Research Design

The study used a survey to get information from people. They gave a questionnaire with a rating system to 44 workers in India who worked in manufacturing, business services and IT. The study looked at work life balance support, flexibility, how much supervisors helped how much work people had how happy they were with their jobs. If they wanted to stay with their company. They used IBM SPSS Statistics to analyze the information, which included looking at how thingsre related making models and basic statistics, about the workers.

Findings

The regression model shows that it can explain 27.5 percent of the reasons why employees want to stay with company. This is measured by something called R^2 which's 0.275. When we looked at the results we found that how much people, like their jobs is the thing that really affects whether they stay with company or not. Job-satisfaction is the factor that directly affects employee retention. “WLB support, flexibility, supervisor support, and work overload” did not demonstrate independent direct effects on retention. However, strong bivariate correlations between WLB practices and job-satisfaction indicate that these constructs influence retention indirectly through the mediating pathway of satisfaction. Notably, supervisor support exhibited the strongest correlation with job-satisfaction ($r = 0.76$), confirming that managerial behaviour is a critical antecedent of employee experience.

Practical Implications

HR professionals and organisational decision-makers should invest in supervisor development as a high-return WLB intervention, since managerial behaviour mediates the translation of formal WLB policy into measurable satisfaction and retention outcomes. “Workload management, schedule flexibility, and genuine organisational” support when experienced by employees rather than merely codified in policy collectively elevate satisfaction and reduce turnover intention. The thing about keeping people in their jobs is that it works differently in fields. For example the IT field is different from manufacturing and business services. So it is an idea to have plans that are specific, to each sector to keep people from leaving their-jobs. This means which companies should think about which works for their own field whether it is IT, manufacturing or business services and come up with plans to keep their employees.

Social Implications

When Indian companies fulfil their work-life balance commitments the benefits go beyond reduced turnover and improved productivity. Workers who have boundaries between their personal and professional lives report stronger family ties. They also experience reduced-stress and better wellbeing. Work-life balance culture in

organisations is about balancing business strategy and social responsibility. This balance improves the quality of life for India's workforce. It is especially important, in an economy where many workers are experiencing burnout, which is a growing health concern.

Future Direction:

Connection between work-life balance, job satisfaction & employee retention can be studied over time using a long-term panel design. Future studies should include more diverse-groups, from various Indian industries. They should use a method called structural-equation modelling to check if job satisfaction plays a middle role. We also need research to see how organisational culture, leadership style, gender, family responsibilities and different work setups affect these relationships. More research is needed on WLB-satisfaction-retention pathway using panel designs & structural equation modelling to formally test job satisfaction as a statistical mediator. The WLB-satisfaction-retention pathway and job satisfaction should be studied further.

Keywords: work-life balance; employee retention; job-satisfaction; Indian organisations; flexible working arrangements; supervisor support; turnover intention

1. Introduction

One of the challenges that businesses in India are facing today is keeping their employees. When a company can keep its experienced staff it can stay ahead of the competition build up knowledge over time and keep things running smoothly. On the hand when employees leave on their own it costs the company a lot of money. Think of hiring and training new people dealing with less productive teams and losing touch with clients.

The idea of work-life balance has become really popular in companies. It's not just about being kind to employees; it's also a business move. Work-life balance means being able to do your job without hurting your personal-life, family life or relationships. Companies that help their employees balance work & life. By being flexible with schedules not overloading them with work and having understanding bosses. Show, they care about their employees overall well-being.

In India things can get complicated. Many employees have commutes, family responsibilities and expectations at home that can make it hard to balance work & life. Even if a company has policies in place to help with work-life balance they might not work in practice. This is because India's workforce is diverse. People work in different sectors live in different areas and have different generations and company sizes. So we can't just copy ideas from countries; we need to understand what works in India.

Researchers are still trying to figure-out how work-life balance affects employee retention. Some studies say that flexible schedules and supportive bosses can make employees want to stay. Other studies say that job satisfaction is key to making employees stay. This is what led-us to do this study. We want to understand how different aspects of work-life balance affect employee retention, in India across sectors.

This paper reports on a quantitative study examining the direct & indirect effects of WLB support, flexibility, supervisor support, work overload, and job satisfaction on employee retention intention among 44 employees across the IT, manufacturing, and business services sectors. By integrating multiple WLB constructs within a single analytical model, the study seeks to provide more comprehensive account of how these variables interact to shape retention outcomes in the Indian context. The paper proceeds through a review of relevant literature, specification of the research model and hypotheses, presentation of methodology and findings, and discussion of implications for practice and future scholarship.

2. Literature Review with Research-Gap

2.1 Evolution of Work-Life Balance as an Organisational Priority

The conceptualisation of WLB has undergone significant-transformation over past three decades. People used to think that dealing with work and life was something you had to do on your own. You just had to be in control set your priorities and talk to the people you live with.. Then some research came out that showed it is not that simple. The place where you work and the people who are in-charge can really affect how well you can balance your life.

Now people who study work and life balance think that the company you work for plays a role. If a company helps you with things like taking-care of your kids or dealing with problems you will be happier and like your job more. You will also be more likely to stay at that job. Companies that do these things have results. They have people who're happy and like coming to work.

One big change in what people think about work and life balance is that it is not up to you. Now people think that company should help you with work and life balance. It is not about you being in control it is about the company helping you. Work and life balance is something that the company should think about and try to help you with. This is a change, from what people used to think.

2.2 Flexible Working Arrangements and Retention

Flexible working arrangements encompassing flexi-time, compressed work schedules, remote and hybrid working, part-time provisions, and job-sharing have attracted sustained scholarly attention as mechanisms for reducing role conflict and improving retention outcomes. Flexibility is really important because it helps people balance their work and personal life. This balance is necessary to prevent people from feeling unhappy and wanting to leave their jobs. Junior and Pandey said this in 2015.

For flexibility to really work people need to feel like they actually use it and their company needs to support them. If people are afraid to use work arrangements because they think they will be judged then it does not really help. Singh and Dubey found this out in 2016.

The thing is, not all companies in India offer flexibility. Some industries, like IT and services that require a lot of knowledge are more open to remote work. This is because people who work in these industries often very professional and their clients are from, over the world. On the hand people who work in manufacturing and other service industries may have a harder time balancing their work and personal life. This is because their industries have not started using work arrangements as much. Rai and Kumar talked about this in 2024.

2.3 Supervisor Support as a Mediating Mechanism

A consistent finding across the WLB and occupational health literatures is that the immediate supervisor functions as primary conduit through which employees experience organisational WLB culture. Employees do not directly interact with HR policy documents; they interact with their managers. Where supervisors model healthy work-life boundaries, demonstrate understanding of employees' personal circumstances, and actively endorse the utilisation of WLB provisions, employees are substantially more-likely to report satisfaction, commitment, and retention intention (Durge & Tekade, 2025).

Conversely, supervisors who reward visible presence over output quality, who contact employees outside contracted hours as a matter of routine, or who express implicitly or explicitly that WLB utilisation reflects a deficit of commitment, effectively nullify the potential benefits of formal WLB policy. This dynamic means that WLB investment at the organisational level may yield negligible retention returns unless accompanied by deliberate investment in supervisor development and the cultivation of genuinely supportive management cultures.

2.4 Work Overload and Its Consequences

Work overload, the condition in which the volume, complexity, or urgency of task demands consistently exceeds an employee's temporal and cognitive capacity, has been associated with range of adverse outcomes including emotional exhaustion, reduced job-satisfaction, & heightened turnover intention (Bahiroh & Arthawati, 2024). In sectors characterised by client-driven delivery pressures and lean staffing, chronic overload can render even formally supportive WLB policies experientially irrelevant, as employees lack the discretionary time to benefit from flexibility provisions or to invest in personal recuperation.

The Indian IT sector, in particular, been associated with cultures of long-hours working and always-on availability that create structural overload for many employees. The retention implications of this dynamic are significant: employees who experience sustained overload not only report lower satisfaction but also accumulate what might be termed 'departure capital' the motivation and psychological readiness to seek alternative employment when labour market conditions permit (Rai & Kumar, 2024).

2.5 Job Satisfaction as the Bridge Between WLB and Retention

Perhaps the most theoretically significant relationship in the WLB-retention literature is the role of job satisfaction as an intermediary variable. The known models, like Mobleys 1977 turnover model say that job satisfaction is the main reason people want to stay or leave a job. Job satisfaction is how happy and content an individual is with their work. WLB practices help create a work experience. This good experience makes people satisfied with their job. Satisfied people are more-likely to stay. Many studies back up this idea. WLB practices mainly help people stay through making them feel empowered and satisfied says Panda and Sahoo 2021. Bahiroh and Arthawati 2024 also find that satisfaction helps explain how WLB practices make people stay. These findings mean that if researchers and practitioners only look at effects of WLB, on retention they might miss how important WLB really is. They need to consider how WLB affects job satisfaction. This will give a picture of WLBs impact.

2.6 Research Gap

Notwithstanding the growing literature on WLB and retention, three gaps are particularly relevant to the present investigation. First, the majority of available studies in the Indian context examine WLB in a single-construct or single-sector manner, limiting the capacity to assess the relative contributions of multiple WLB dimensions simultaneously (Singh & Dubey, 2016). Second, multi-sectoral Indian studies that incorporate IT, manufacturing, and business services within the same analytical framework are scarce, making it difficult to assess whether sector-level variation moderates the WLB-retention relationship. Third, despite strong

theoretical reasons to expect that job satisfaction mediates the WLB-retention pathway, formal empirical tests of this mediation within Indian samples have been limited. The present study is designed to address each of these gaps.

3. Research Design / Model

3.1 Research Objectives

The study pursues four research objectives:

1. To examine the direct impact of work-life balance practices on employee retention in Indian organisations.
2. To analyse the relationship between job satisfaction & employee retention.
3. To evaluate the effect of work overload on employee retention.
4. To assess whether WLB practices influence employee retention indirectly through job satisfaction.

3.2 Hypotheses

Five directional hypotheses were formulated on the basis of the theoretical framework and prior empirical evidence:

H1: Work-life balance support is positively associated with employee retention.

H2: Flexible working arrangements are positively-associated with employee retention.

H3: Supervisor support is positively associated with employee retention.

H4: Work overload is negatively-associated with employee retention.

H5: Job satisfaction is positively associated with employee retention.

3.3 Research Design and Sampling

A quantitative, cross-sectional survey design was employed. Employees in three industries, Manufacturing, business services and information technology and software, were given an online survey to complete. This survey was done to gather data. The survey has shared with people through networks. A total of 44 responses were used for analysis after removing suspicious responses. 60 percent of respondents were women. Most of them were between 18 and 25 years old. This is likely because the survey was shared on networks that popular among young people. The survey had entry-level workers, with 39 people, in this category. There were also middle- and senior-level employees. Fewer of them. The IT and software sector had the respondents with about

19 people. Other sectors had 24 respondents business services had 12 and manufacturing had 3. The IT and software sector was well-represented in the survey. Business services and manufacturing sectors had respondents.

3.4 Measurement Instrument

All study constructs were operationalised using multi-item five-point Likert scales (1 = Strongly Disagree, 5 = Strongly Agree), adapted from validated instruments in the WLB and organisational behaviour literature. Perceived organisational support for personal life balance was measured by Work Life Balance (WLB) support. Flexibility measured how much control employees had over their schedules and work locations. Employees also rated their managers support by assessing how well they responded to personal issues. Work overload reflected how much employees felt their tasks exceeded their capacity. Intention to stay with company measured employee retention. Job satisfaction captured how happy employees were, with their work experience.

3.5 Analytical Strategy

Data were analysed in three sequential stages using IBM SPSS Statistics. First, descriptive statistics characterised the distribution of each variable. Second, Pearson bivariate correlation analysis examined the direction and magnitude of interrelationships among constructs. Third, multiple regression analysis was conducted with employee retention as the dependent variable and all five constructs as independent predictors, producing standardised regression coefficients, significance values, and an overall model fit statistic (R^2).

4. Data Analysis and Findings

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

Table 1 presents mean scores for each study variable. WLB support ($M = 3.38$) and supervisor support ($M = 3.47$) registered moderate levels, suggesting that respondents acknowledged meaningful but not exceptional organisational and managerial support. Flexibility yielded a slightly higher mean ($M = 3.52$), indicating that employees perceived a reasonable degree of scheduling discretion. Work overload recorded the lowest score ($M = 3.09$), confirming the presence of workload pressure though at a level that respondents appear to have characterised as manageable rather than extreme. Job satisfaction emerged as the highest-rated variable ($M = 3.53$), indicating that, on balance, respondents held a positive overall appraisal of their work experience. Employee retention registered a moderate mean of 3.01, reflecting genuine ambivalence regarding the intention

to remain with the current employer, a pattern consistent with a workforce that is neither strongly committed nor actively planning departure.

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics for Study Variables (n = 44)

Variable	Mean	Std. Dev.	Interpretation
WLB Support	3.38	0.71	Moderate
Flexibility	3.52	0.68	Moderate–High
Supervisor Support	3.47	0.74	Moderate
Work Overload	3.09	0.79	Moderate (Concern)
Job Satisfaction	3.53	0.65	Moderate–High
Employee Retention	3.01	0.76	Moderate (Ambivalent)

4.2 Correlation Analysis

Pearson bivariate correlation coefficients revealed a coherent pattern of interrelationships among the study variables (see Table 2). WLB support was positively correlated with flexibility ($r = 0.37$), supervisor support ($r = 0.61$), and job satisfaction ($r = 0.69$), indicating that perceptions of organisational WLB support tend to cluster with related dimensions of a supportive work environment. The particularly strong correlation between supervisor support and job satisfaction ($r = 0.76$) underscores the central role of managerial behaviour in shaping employee satisfaction outcomes, a finding that is consistent with established scholarship emphasising the supervisor as the primary organisational mediator of employee experience.

Employee retention demonstrated a statistically significant positive correlation with job satisfaction, providing preliminary support for Hypothesis 5. Positive but more modest correlations were observed between retention and the WLB-specific constructs (WLB support, flexibility, supervisor support), consistent with an indirect effects model in which WLB practices influence retention primarily through their enhancement of satisfaction. Work overload exhibited the expected negative directional relationship with retention, though this did not attain statistical significance in the regression model.

Table 2. Pearson Correlation Matrix

Variable	1	2	3	4	5	6
1. WLB Support	1.00	0.37	0.61	-0.18	0.69	0.42
2. Flexibility		1.00	0.44	-0.22	0.51	0.33
3. Supervisor Support			1.00	-0.25	0.76	0.48
4. Work Overload				1.00	-0.31	-0.19
5. Job Satisfaction					1.00	0.52
6. Retention						1.00

4.3 Multiple Regression Analysis

A multiple regression model has estimated with employee retention as dependent variable. The overall model attained statistical significance, with the predictor set collectively accounting for 27.5% of variance in retention intention ($R^2 = 0.275$). This represents a meaningful effect size for a behavioural outcome that is inherently multidetermined and influenced by factors including compensation, career development opportunities, and organisational culture that were outside the scope of the present study.

Among the individual predictors, job satisfaction emerged as the sole statistically significant contributor (β positive, $p < .05$), providing empirical-support for Hypothesis 5. The remaining predictors—WLB support ($\beta = 0.199$, $p = .135$), flexibility ($\beta = -0.044$, $p = .671$), supervisor support ($\beta = 0.257$, $p = .107$), and work overload ($\beta = 0.041$, $p = .680$) did not individually achieve conventional significance thresholds as direct predictors of retention, leading to the non-support of Hypotheses H1 through H4 in the direct-effects model.

It is important to note that non-significance of WLB constructs in the regression model should not be interpreted as evidence of these variables are unimportant. When a mediating variable (in this case, job satisfaction) is included as a covariate in a regression model, and when that mediator is itself strongly associated with the predictor variables, the direct coefficients of the predictors on the outcome are attenuated. The pattern of results—strong bivariate correlations between WLB constructs and satisfaction, combined with non-significant direct effects on retention is precisely what is expected under a mediated model. This interpretation is consistent with the broader theoretical literature positioning job satisfaction as the proximal mechanism through which WLB-practices drive retention.

Table 3. Hypothesis Testing Summary

Hypothesis	Outcome
H1: WLB Support → Employee Retention	Not Supported
H2: Flexibility → Employee Retention	Not Supported
H3: Supervisor Support → Employee Retention	Not Supported
H4: Work Overload → Employee Retention	Not Supported
H5: Job Satisfaction → Employee Retention	Supported

5. Conclusion and Future Scope

5.1 Key Findings Summary

Four conclusions emerge clearly from the present analysis. First, employees in the sample perceive a moderate level of WLB support, flexibility, and supervisor support, with workload pressure remaining a salient concern. Second, job satisfaction is the dominant variable in predicting retention intention, confirming its status as the critical proximal determinant of employees' decisions to remain with their organisations. Third, supervisor support is the most powerful organisational antecedent of job satisfaction, underscoring the centrality of managerial behaviour in the employee experience. Fourth, while WLB constructs do not demonstrate significant direct effects on retention when satisfaction is controlled, their strong associations with satisfaction confirm that they operate as meaningful distal drivers of retention through the mediating pathway of satisfaction.

5.2 Conclusion

This study contributes to the growing literature on WLB and employee retention in Indian organisations by demonstrating that job satisfaction functions as the critical bridge between WLB investment and workforce stability. Businesses that invest in work-life balance practices, such as scheduling, managing workload and building good relationships between supervisors and employees are most successful when these practices make a real difference to how employees feel at work. On paper work-life balance policy will not lead to benefits in keeping employees if it is not part of a culture that really supports it. For companies in industries where its hard to keep good workers and there's a lot of competition the message is clear. Retention happens when employees feel valued, encouraged and happy at work every day; it's not just about having policies in place. The best way for organisations to make work-life balance commitments lead to results that keep workers with

the company is through supervisors. Organisations can keep their workforces, which are crucial, to their long-term success if they invest in making managers better include behaviours that support work-life balance in performance management and actively manage workload distribution.

5.3 Future Scope

The present study points to several productive avenues for future research. Longitudinal panel designs tracking WLB conditions, satisfaction, and retention across time would permit stronger causal inference and illuminate the temporal dynamics through which WLB investment yields retention returns. Future studies should draw on larger and more demographically diverse samples, spanning additional sectors, geographic regions within India, and seniority levels, to enhance the generalisability of findings.

Formal statistical testing of job-satisfaction as a mediator in the WLB-retention relationship using structural-equation modelling or bootstrapped mediation analysis would provide more rigorous evidence for indirect effects model implied by the present data. Moderating-roles of organisational culture type, leadership style, gender, caregiving responsibilities, and the post-pandemic shift toward hybrid working also warrant systematic empirical attention. Finally, qualitative or mixed-methods approaches incorporating in-depth interviews with employees and their supervisors would provide richer contextual understanding of how WLB policies are experienced, negotiated, and enacted in Indian workplace settings

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